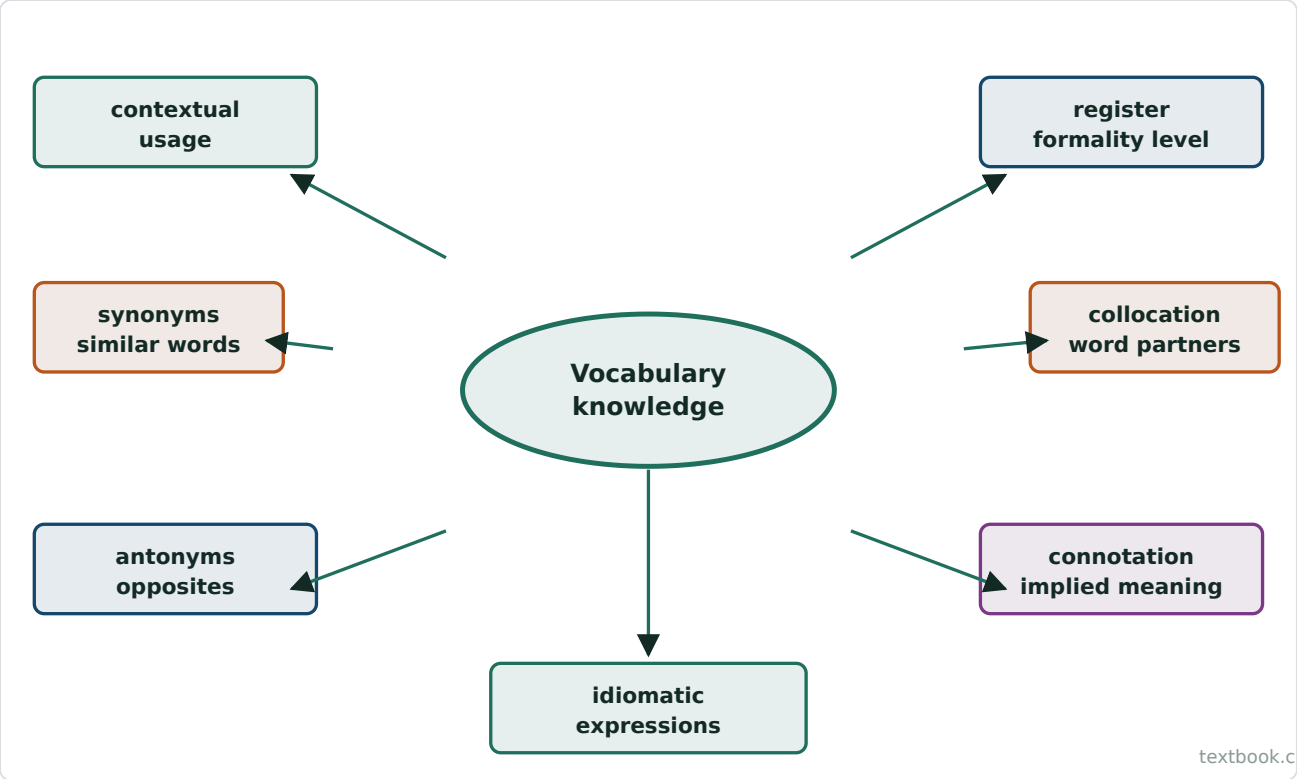
Draft - expert review pending

This unit is complete and passes the platform’s automated checks, but no reviewer has read it yet. Treat its sources and claims with care.

Topic 1.1 - Words in context: vocabulary and grammar

A real classroom situation



textbook.com.pk

Miss Ayesha teaches Class 9 English in a government school in Karachi. She asks her pupils to write a letter to the headteacher requesting a library card. One pupil writes: "I am needing the card for reading books." The grammar is understandable but not natural. Another writes: "Kindly issue me the card at your earliest convenience." The grammar is correct but the tone is too formal

for a pupil. This topic is about the choices that make English natural, correct, and appropriate to the situation.

Explanation

Effective English is not just about knowing words and rules. It is about choosing the right word for the right context and applying grammar so that meaning is clear. This topic covers the two foundations: vocabulary in context and communicative grammar.

Vocabulary in context

A word means different things in different contexts. The word "run", for example, has over forty meanings in English. In a classroom, "run an activity" is different from "run for election" or "a run in your stocking". Understanding vocabulary means understanding these distinctions.

Register is the level of formality a situation demands. A conversation with a friend uses an informal register; a letter to a headteacher uses a formal register. Pakistani English often mixes registers in ways that sound unnatural to a fluent speaker. The figure above maps the components of vocabulary knowledge.

Collocation is the tendency of certain words to appear together. In English, we make a decision (not do a decision), we take a photo (not make a photo), and we commit a mistake (not make a mistake, though this is common in Pakistani English). Learning collocations is more useful than learning individual words.

Connotation is the feeling or association a word carries beyond its literal meaning. "Thin" and "slim" both describe a person of low weight, but "slim" has a positive connotation and "thin" can be negative. Choosing words with the right connotation is part of choosing words with the right register.

Synonyms, antonyms and idiomatic expressions. Synonyms are words with similar meanings (big, large, enormous), but they are rarely interchangeable. Antonyms are words with opposite meanings (hot/cold, fast/slow). Idiomatic expressions are phrases whose meaning cannot be guessed from the individual words ("kick the bucket" means to die, not to kick a bucket).

Urdu has its own rich set of idioms, and direct translation often produces confusion.

Communicative grammar

Communicative grammar is the study of how grammar creates meaning in real communication, not as a set of abstract rules. The guide lists several areas where Pakistani learners commonly make errors.

Subject-verb agreement. The verb must agree with the subject in number. "The pupils reads" is incorrect because "pupils" is plural. Common difficulties include collective nouns (the team is/ are), indefinite pronouns (everyone is/are), and sentences where the subject and verb are separated by a long phrase.

Verb tenses. English has twelve verb tenses, but the most common sources of error are the present perfect ("I have done" vs. "I did"), the past continuous ("I was doing"), and the conditionals ("If I were you, I would..."). Urdu has a different tense system, so direct transfer produces errors.

Fragments and run-ons. A fragment is an incomplete sentence that lacks a subject or a verb ("Because I was tired"). A run-on is two complete sentences joined without proper punctuation ("I was tired I went to bed"). Both are common in Pakistani student writing.

Modifiers. A modifier describes another word. A misplaced modifier creates confusion ("Running quickly, the finish line appeared" suggests the finish line was running). Dangling modifiers have no clear word to modify.

Articles. "A", "an" and "the" are among the hardest parts of English grammar for Urdu speakers because Urdu has no direct equivalent. The rules are complex, but the most common errors are omitting "the" when it is needed (I went to school vs. I went to the school) and using "the" when it is not needed.

Word classes. The eight word classes (noun, pronoun, verb, adverb, adjective, preposition, conjunction, interjection) are the building blocks of sentences. Being able to identify them helps you understand why a sentence works or does not.

Common grammatical errors

six frequent error types with an example and the correction

Error type	Mistake example	Correction
subject-verb agreement	The list of items are long.	The list of items is long.
verb tenses wrong past form	Yesterday I go to the market.	Yesterday I went to the market.
sentence fragments	Because it was raining.	We stayed in because it was raining.
run-on sentences	It was late we went home.	It was late, so we went home.
misplaced modifiers	She almost drove the kids to school every day.	She drove the kids to school almost every day.
articles	He is a honest man.	He is an honest man.

textbook.com.pk

textbook.com.pk

The figure above maps the most common grammatical errors, their corrections, and the principle behind each correction. Use it as a reference when you write.

Common misconception. "Grammar rules are fixed and universal." They are not. English grammar describes how fluent speakers actually use the language, and usage varies by region, register and context. The goal is not perfection but clarity and appropriateness.

Activity: Analyse a text for vocabulary and grammar

Work in pairs. Take a short text (a newspaper editorial, a textbook paragraph, or a pupil's essay). First, identify five words whose meaning depends on context and explain what they mean in this context. Second, identify three grammatical structures (tenses, articles, subject-verb agreement) and explain why they are used. Allow 25 minutes. Then present your findings to another pair and discuss any disagreements.

Check your understanding

1. Explain the difference between register and connotation, and give one example of each. *(Remember)*
2. A pupil writes, "The group of students was arguing among themselves." Identify the subject-verb agreement issue and explain why it is difficult. *(Analyze)*
3. Name the four sentence structures (simple, compound, complex, compound-complex) and write one example of each. *(Remember)*
4. Identify the article error in this sentence and explain the principle: "She is doctor at the Civil Hospital." *(Apply)*
5. Rewrite this sentence so the modifier is not dangling: "Walking to school, the rain started suddenly." *(Apply)*

Summary

Vocabulary in context means understanding register, collocation, connotation and denotation, not just memorising word lists. Communicative grammar means understanding how grammar creates meaning in real communication, not just memorising rules. The most common grammatical errors made by Pakistani learners involve subject-verb agreement, verb tenses, fragments, run-ons, modifiers and articles.

Self-assessment checklist

Sign in to sync your ticks across devices.

- [ ] I can explain the difference between register, collocation and connotation.
- [ ] I can identify and correct common subject-verb agreement errors.
- [ ] I can distinguish fragments from run-ons and correct both.
- [ ] I can explain the main rules for article usage.
- [ ] I can identify the eight word classes in a sample sentence.

Try this at your practicum school

Collect five samples of pupil writing (essays, answers to exam questions, or creative writing). For each sample, identify three vocabulary issues (wrong register, inappropriate collocation, or incorrect connotation) and three grammatical errors. Write half a page on the most common pattern you observe and what teaching strategy you would use to address it.

Do not name the school or the pupils in your write-up.

Summative task

Write 350 to 400 words on the following.

> A pupil in your practicum school writes: "I am having two brothers and one sister. My father is doing job in a bank. We are living in Lahore since five years." Using this topic's account of communicative grammar, identify four grammatical issues, explain why each is an error, and rewrite the sentences so they are natural and correct.

Mini-rubric

Criterion	What a strong response does
Identification of the four issues (Understand)	Names the error type (tense, article, preposition, collocation) accurately
Explanation of why each is wrong (Analyze)	Explains the grammatical principle, not just that it sounds wrong
Rewritten sentences (Apply)	**Produces natural, correct sentences that preserve the original meaning**
Register and clarity	Writes for a colleague, defines any technical term used, stays within the word count

Further reading

- Azar, B. S. *Understanding and Using English Grammar.* (guide recommended)
- Murphy, R. *English Grammar in Use.* (guide recommended)
- Swan, M. *Practical English Usage.* (guide recommended)

Tip: select any text on this page first to comment on that specific passage - or leave nothing selected for general feedback.

Give feedback